

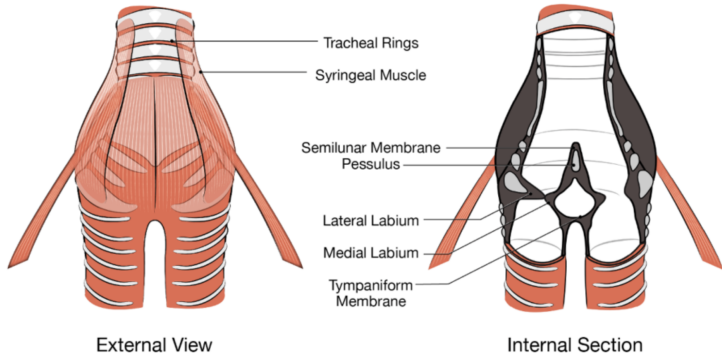


## Vocalizations

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Office: 305 Lewis Hall

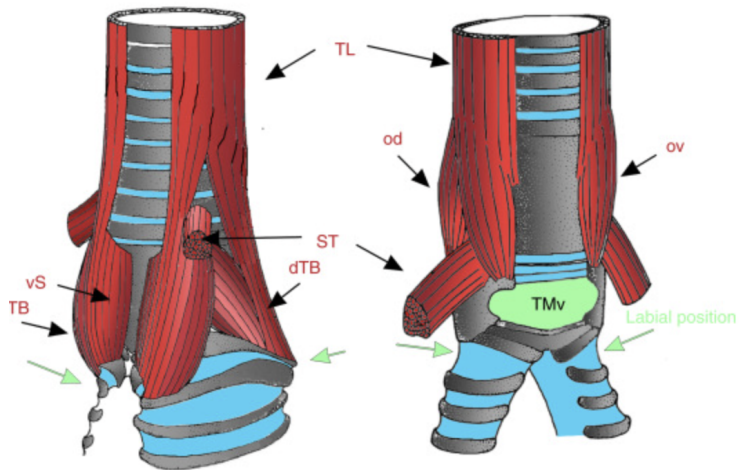
# The avian syrinx

- ▶ Located at junction of bronchi and trachea (c.f. **larynx** at top of neck)
- ▶ Sounds produced by forcing air through syrinx, reducing static pressure on syringeal membranes flanking interclavicular air sac (Bernoulli effect!)



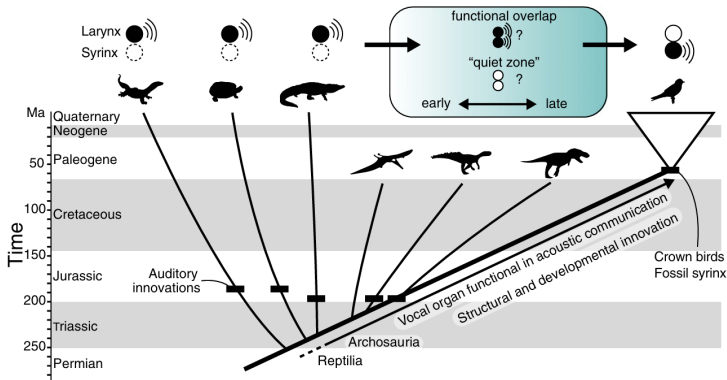
## Syrinx anatomy varies with vocal ability

- ▶ L: typical oscine songbird syrinx with both **tracheal** and **bronchial** elements
- ▶ R: suboscine song syrinx with only tracheal elements



# Syrinx evolution

- ▶ ancestor of birds lost ability to make sounds with **larynx**, re-evolved ability with **syrinx** (an **evolutionary novelty**)

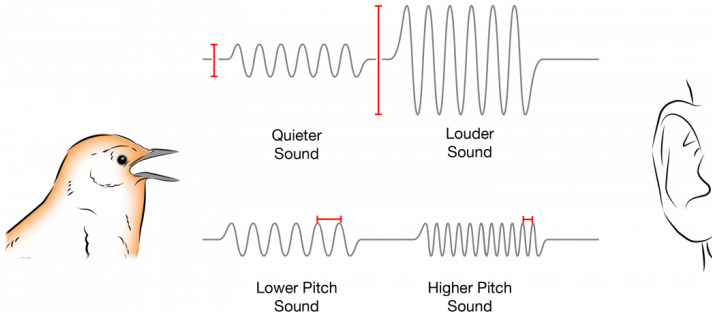


(Kinglsey et al. 2018)



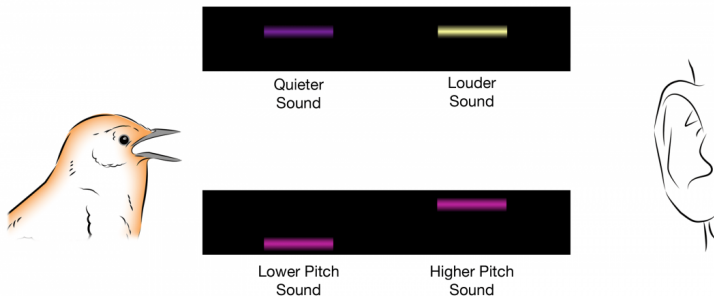
# Bird song physics

- ▶ **amplitude:** height of soundwaves = “loudness”
- ▶ **frequency:** distance between peaks of soundwaves = pitch



# Spectrograms

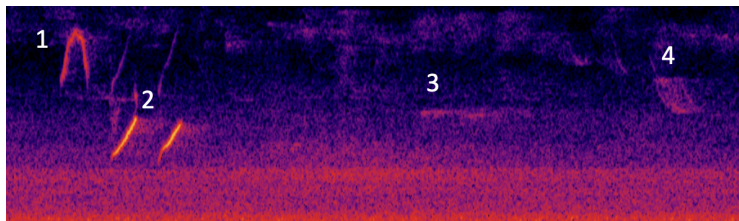
- **Spectrograms** visualize both amplitude and frequency



[https://macaulaylibrary.org/asset/61838;](https://macaulaylibrary.org/asset/61838)

<https://macaulaylibrary.org/asset/27193>

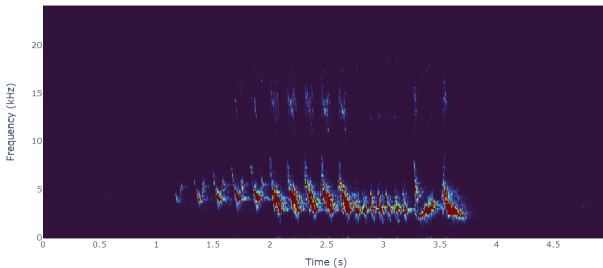
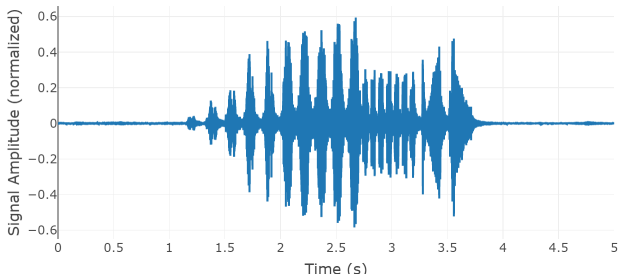
Which feature of this song is *loudest*?



<https://xeno-canto.org/1183619>

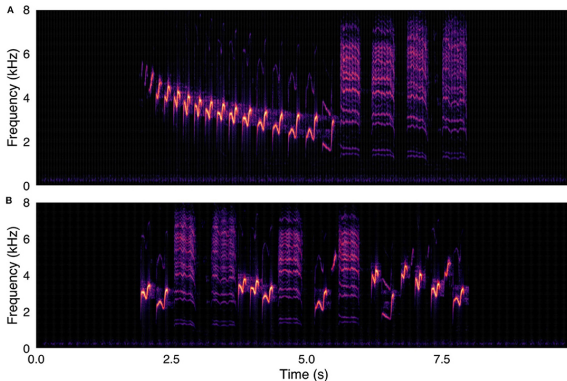
- a) 1
- b) 2
- c) 3
- d) 4

# Data from spectrograms and waveforms used in Merlin



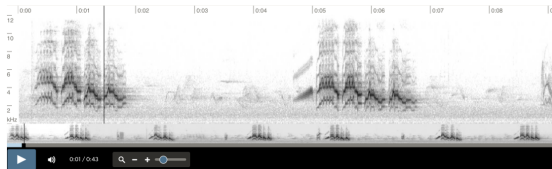
# Harmonics

- ▶ Multiple sound producing areas in syrinx = multiple simultaneous notes
- ▶ Harmonics are multiples of a “fundamental frequency”



<https://macaulaylibrary.org/asset/224190551>

# Self-duetting

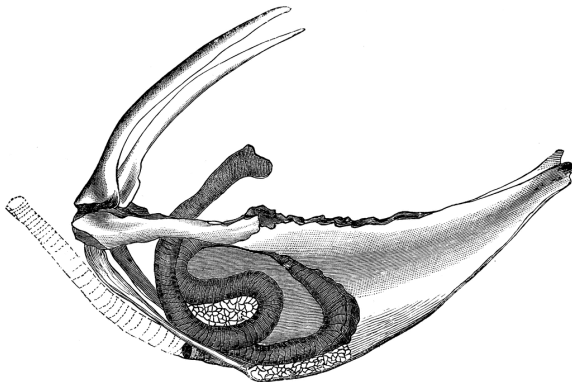


<https://earbirding.com/blog/archives/3711>

ML476610461; ML3093086;

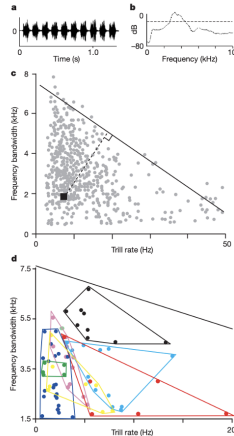
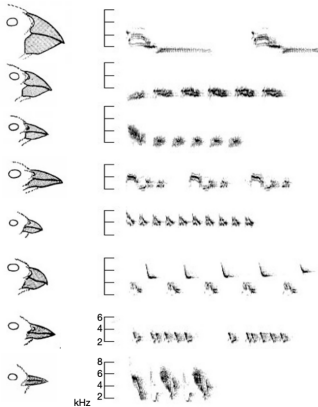
## Post-source modulation

- ▶ **filtering** eliminates or enhances certain vocal frequencies by interference with features in vocal cavity (e.g., bill)
- ▶ **post-source modulation** refers to altering sounds from syrinx via changes in length, shape, size of vocal cavity



# Feeding ecology constrains song

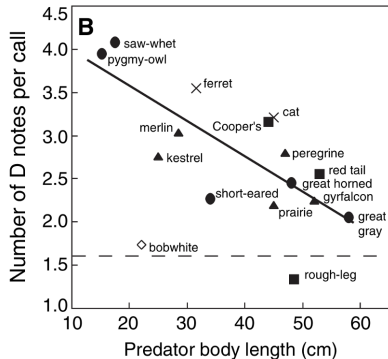
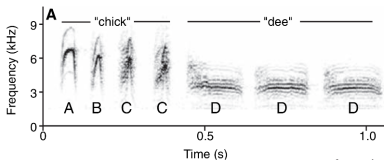
- ▶ Bill size reflects adaptations to seed size
- ▶ High rate, pure-tone trills are physically impossible for birds with large bills





# Chickadees encode information on predator size in song

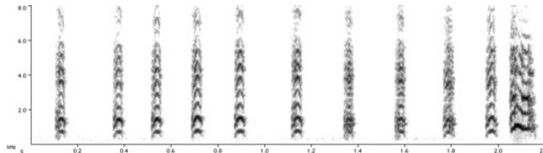
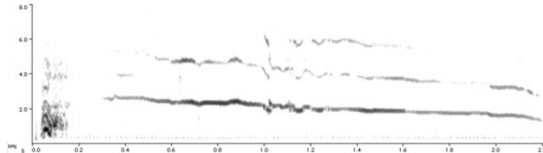
- ▶ Number of harmonic “dees” negatively correlates to predator body size (smaller = bigger threat)



(Podos 2001)

# Binaural comparison to locate predators

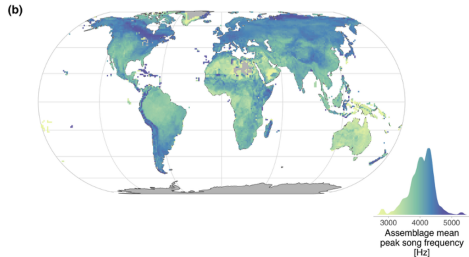
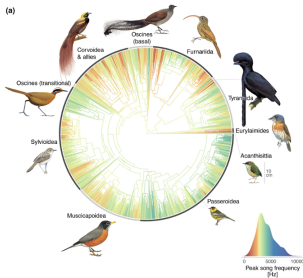
- ▶ **aerial predators** (top): limited amplitude, long waves scatter, difficult to source
- ▶ **ground predators** (bottom): large amplitude, short, lots of location information



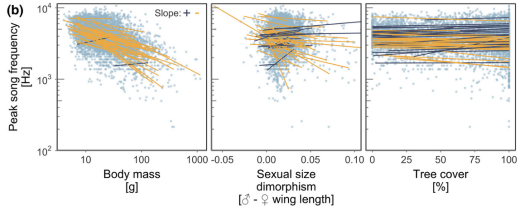
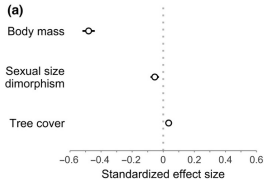
(*Gallus gallus* calls, Aves Biology / Gary Ritchison)

# Acoustic adaptation hypothesis

- ▶  $H_1$ : Birds in denser habitats will have lower calls
- ▶ Methods: Meta-analysis of frequencies paired with habitat cover



# Is the acoustic adaptation hypothesis supported?



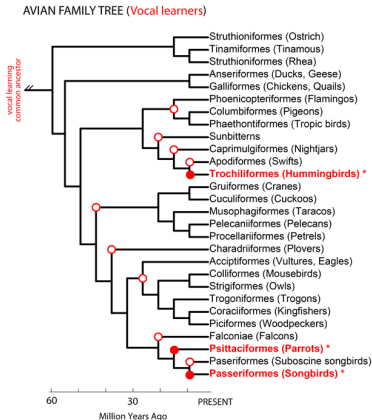
- a) yes
- b) no
- c) impossible to say
- d) it depends

(But see: <https://www.youtube.com/watch?v=iy-9Z2KrjsY>)

(Mikula et al. 2021)

# Vocal learning is rare but has evolved multiple times

- Found in parrots, songbirds, hummingbirds, humans, bats, and whales

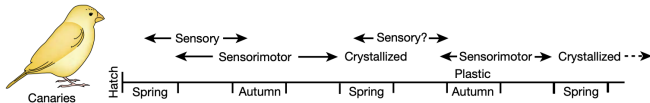
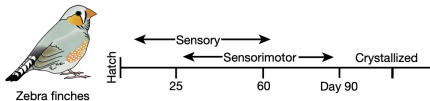
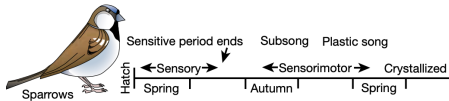


\* Vocal learners: Alternative hypotheses

- 3 independent gain
- 9 independent losses
- every animal has it to varying degrees

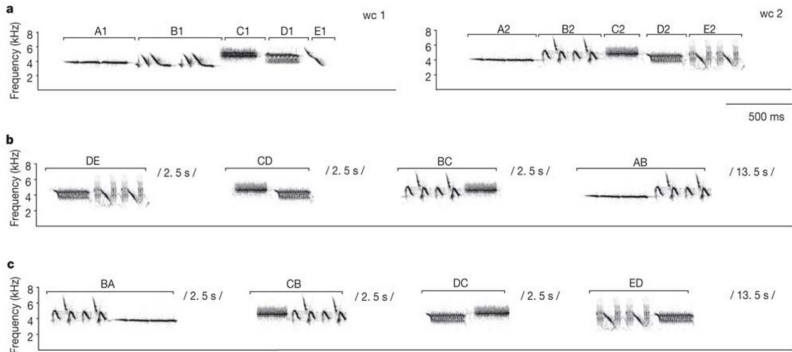
# Phases of song learning

- ▶ **sensory acquisition phase:** innate “template” modified by auditory environment
- ▶ **sensorimotor phase:** practices **subsong** to develop **plastic** (flexible but complete) song
- ▶ **crystalized phase:** stable adult song



# Phases of song learning

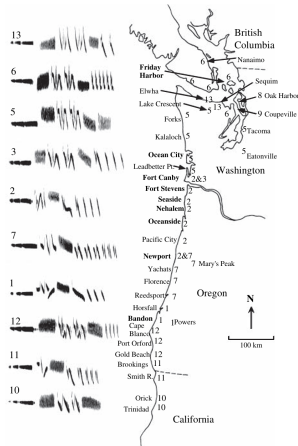
- ▶ White-crowned Sparrows only use phrases from “tutors”



(Rose et al. 2004)

# Learned song variation

- ▶ **dialects:** geographically constrained song variants
- ▶ **repertoire:** the set of songs an individual knows



(Nelson et al. 2004)



Which of the following will NOT influence calls in tinamous?



- a) Bill size
- b) Habitat
- c) Parental repertoire
- d) Syrinx anatomy

*Tinamotis ingoufi*

# Mimicry

- ▶ ~20% of passerine songbirds practice mimicry



<https://www.youtube.com/watch?v=mSB71jNq-yQ>

## References

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